Beach Day

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/65328721.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Part 1 of I'll Meet You There

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by firelikestars

Summary

Hordak sends the Super Pal Trio to retrieve a piece of First Ones tech off the coast of Salineas. Everything goes according to plan, until Adora shows up.

Notes

CAT!!

here i am, venturing out of my main fandom to write this goofy little one shot for your birthday because i love you.

i wish you the happiest of birthdays today, you deserve it!!! you are so fucking awesome and an amazing friend, and although a little story isn't nearly enough to show how much you mean to me, i hope it generally gets the point across.

if you're a she-ra fan (which i'm assuming you are if you're about to read this), go check out their amazing fics!

enjoy the read cat :) <3

“This is *not* a ‘beach day,’” Catra growled, her tail flicking rapidly across the bottom of the skiff.

“I have to agree with Scorpia, considering the fact that we’ll be spending the day on a beach,” said Entrapta. “Most of it, anyway.”

“I didn’t ask for your opinion, Entrapta. We’ll be on the beach for as long as it takes to dig up tech, and then we’re *leaving.* That’s not a ‘beach day,’” Catra insisted sternly, glaring at the both of them.

Scorpia, as always, was undeterred. “Not with that attitude!” she replied with a bright smile. “Come on, wildcat, we’re away from the Horde for a day! No Hordak, no weird burning smell that I can never find the source of, and this thing is *way* fancier than a boat. Don’t you love it? No seasickness!”

Love was very far from Catra’s current reality. Going to the beach meant that everything would be too bright and surrounded by *water.* She had managed to keep the skiff high enough that the ocean was at an almost tolerable distance below them, but the smell was still strong enough that she was flattening the fear out of her tail every few minutes.

It wasn't the worst mission Catra had been on by far, but there were still a million things she’d rather be doing. The only thing that kept her hand on the accelerator was the thought of Shadow Weaver’s sour, jealous face when they brought a huge piece of

First One's tech back to Hordak. That was something worth risking getting wet for.

Still, it was stupid that she had to be there at all. Hordak had decided that Entrapta needed more than just Scorpia for this mission and asked Catra to keep a lookout. It took restraint not to laugh in his face. Since when did Hordak start making sure anyone on the force was looked after? Underneath the urge to laugh, jealousy smacked her like a wave, like a stupid wave she shouldn't have to be anywhere near in the first place.

"Let's just get this over with," Catra grumbled, forcing a deep breath into her lungs as began to maneuver the skiff downwards.

As far as kingdoms go, Salineas was the most princessy of them all. It was insufferable. All around them were towering, shell-shaped spires, aquatic sculptures were carved into the stone closest to the sea gate, and the water was faintly glowing from its close proximity to the Pearl. Luckily they didn't need to be anywhere close to the center of it.

About a week ago, Entrapta had sent a drone to fly around the scattered collection of islands near Salineas, claiming that all kinds of things end up in the ocean. Sunken ships, trash, and apparently, abandoned tech.

Yesterday the drone finally spotted something. Unfortunately, whatever it was was mosty buried under sand 70 feet past the shoreline. Even though Entrapta had somehow figured out when low tide would be that day, the tech would still be about 40 feet

away from dry land when they arrived. 40 feet Catra was absolutely not going to swim.

She steered the skiff down to the sandy beaches of the small island they were targeting, landing them behind the coverage of a large pointed boulder where they could avoid detection from any scouts guarding the gate. The island was cluttered with a seriously unfortunate amount of kelp. The smell was unbearable.

To make matters worse, before they even stepped onto the sand Catra had to resist clenching her teeth as Scorpia yet again tried to give her a headache.

"Super Pal Trio goes to the beach. Totally us!" she said, wrapping an arm around Catra's shoulder and pulling her in for a side hug.

Entrapta was lucky enough to escape her other arm, scurrying off towards the ocean with an overly enthusiastic cackle.

Just as Catra was about to shove her off with a firm word about personal space, Scorpia moved away with a sound that somehow managed to be both exasperated and chipper at the same time.

"Entrapta! You forgot your disguise!" Scorpia called after her, picking up a stack of clothes from a crate behind them and following Entrapta down the beach.

Catra finally treated herself to that jaw clench. For some reason, Scorpia had decided that not only was this a 'beach day,' it was also a spy mission, and apparently it was required that they go undercover. She even invented a jingle about sneaking around. A pointed mention of the emergency duct tape in the trunk managed to stop her from singing it over and over on their way there, but the outfits had already been packed.

Sure, it would've been easy to just throw the whole crate overboard, but Scorpia had decided that of all possible places to sit, that particular crate was the most comfortable. Whatever. Just because the outfit made it to the island didn't mean she was going to wear it.

Scorpia, who had dressed in a pink ball gown before they even left, had finally gotten ahold of Entrapta and was now helping her into a red ruffled skirt.

With her tail twitching in irritation, Catra begrudgingly made her way over to them, forcing one foot in front of the other until she was at the shoreline. "Alright, where is this thing?"

Scorpia turned to her as she approached. "Oh, not you, too! I know you didn't like my song, but it makes it so much easier to remember why the disguises are important!" she said, taking a deep breath before inevitably breaking into song again. "How could I sneak with this fine–"

"One more word and I will *actually* tape your mouth shut. I already told you, I'm not wearing a stupid disguise."

"If you're concerned about how you'll look, I totally understand, but you don't need to worry! I spent an hour picking yours out, I think the hat will really compliment your eyes. Stay right there, I'll go get it," she replied, and headed back to the skiff.

Catra glared at her as she left. "Entrapta, tell me you can dig up this tech before Scorpia gets back."

"I can tell you that, if you want me to lie. Scorpia walks at approximately 3 miles per hour, and based on the sheer size of the artifact I've discovered it's going to take at *least–"*

"Yeah, yeah. Just start digging," Catra interrupted.

With an excited shriek, Entrapta dug her ponytails into the sand, launched herself into the air, and landed in the ocean with a splash.

Catra backed up a few steps to avoid the spray and crossed her arms. Time to get this over with and go home.

A few seconds later, Scorpia was trudging back to the shore again. "Okay, so here's the beach hat, and I chose this shirt because I felt like the black really emphasized how cool and strong you are. It might be a little tricky to put on, but I'm here to help. Let's just

put your arm in here," she said, trying to push a sleeve over Catra's hand.

Catra swatted her hand away with a hiss. "I said I'm not wearing it!"

"We have to keep you safe! This is just a precaution in case anyone sees us," Scorpia replied.

"If you keep trying to get me to wear your ugly clothes, you're the only one here who isn't going to be safe," Catra said with a glare.

After a few more minutes of arguing and hissing and swatting, the shirt ended up in the water but Catra eventually agreed to wear the beach hat. Only to get Scorpia to shut up. Conceding had nothing to do with the way that stubborn worried look on her face made her feel.

"I've located the artifact!" Entrapta yelled from across the water. Her hair was splayed out around her like some kind of purple mermaid. "Let me just get my strength fortified gauntlets and my propulsion pack and I'll start lifting it out of the water."

Catra frowned. "I thought Scorpia was going to be the one lifting it."

“Oh, no. I mean, she can, if she wants to, but this is the perfect opportunity to test out my gauntlets. Scorpia just wanted to keep us company,” Entrapta replied as she waded to the shore, her fluffy skirt dragging behind her.

“Right,” Catra grumbled, ignoring the friendly smile Scorpia was aiming in her direction.

“Wow!” Scorpia squealed. “Look at that, this little fella has pincers just like me! Hey bud!”

Catra glanced over to see Scorpia crouching down near a shelled creature skittering across the sand.

“I love the beach. The sand really sticks together close to the water, have you noticed that?” Scorpia continued.

“No,” Catra replied, watching the creature crawl into a small hole.

“I thought it might be fun to try and make shapes out of it. Who knows, maybe I’ll start a trend! I’ll call it… *sand shapes.”*

Catra shot her a condescending look. “Sure. Well, since Entrapta seems to have it all under control, I’ll go supervise from over there.”

“I’ll be over here if you need anything, making sand shapes. Gosh, being creative is fun,” said Scorpia.

Catra rolled her eyes and navigated around large piles of kelp until she was a safe distance away from the water. Safe enough, at least.

Finding a rock that was at least somewhat flat on top, she climbed up and perched on its peak. With a yawn, she stretched out and watched as Entrapta bobbed in and out of the water for the occasional breath, and Scorpia began to dig.

At least it wasn't as nauseatingly bright as she expected it to be. Clusters of lazy clouds dulled the light of the moons, and there was even a light breeze ruffling through her fur. The sound of the water was very unhelpful for any kind of relaxation, but Catra had to admit it was nice to get away from the Horde for a while. Entrapta clearly had things handled, and for a moment, no one was expecting anything of her.

There was no doubt that Shadow Weaver and Hordak were waiting for her back at the Horde to return a failure, but that was for future Catra to deal with. Right now, she wasn’t being watched, she wasn’t being listened to, and as long as Entrapta didn’t run off somewhere where she couldn’t be rescued, there was no way Catra could mess this one up.

She allowed herself to close her eyes, adjusting her ears to make up for the lack of surveillance. Taking a deep breath, she curled

further inwards on herself, and after a while, something unfamiliar began to envelop her. Calm.

Unfortunately, Catra wasn't born for luxury.

Hearing a soft sound in the distance, her eyes flew open. The only person she could see was Scorpia; she was creating some kind of looming sand monstrosity, but she wasn't walking. Catra's ears twitched and pivoted around her, trying to locate the source of what sounded like approaching footsteps. She slowly rose to a crouch, searching for any unwelcome visitors.

There.

Off in the distance, a small boat had come ashore, and walking across the sand was someone in a red shirt with a blonde ponytail. Catra's tail rose with her heart rate. Perfect. She narrowed her eyes and smirked. What a nice little trophy to bring home along with the shiny new tech. Gracefully leaping down from the boulder, she stalked across the beach, making quick work of the space between her and Adora.

Right as Catra was about to pounce, heavy thudding footsteps alerted her prey.

Adora whirled around. "For the honor of– Ahh!" she screamed as Scorpia tackled her to the ground.

“I had it handled!” Catra yelled as Scorpia tossed her the sword. She stabbed it into the sand with a loud growl and turned to glare at Adora. “What the hell are you doing here?”

“Yeah! And on our beach day, of all days? Why are you always showing up at the worst possible times?” Scorpia asked, easily keeping Adora pinned to the ground.

Adora looked up at Catra with a chuckle. “You guys are having a beach day?”

“We’re on a *mission* ,” Catra replied, shooting daggers at Scorpia. “What are you doing here?”

“What are you wearing?” Adora asked, her smile spreading wider across her face.

Catra flushed a deep pink. She snatched the hat off her head and chucked it as far as she could into the ocean.

“Aw, man, not again,” Scorpia lamented, gazing across the water.

“I’m asking the questions here, princess,” Catra snapped, “now answer before I make Scorpia cut that stupid pouf out of your hair.”

"Jeez, calm down. It's Glimmer's birthday tomorrow and I'm coming to pick up Mermista's gift for her. She was a little late getting everything together so I offered to–"

"Yeah, I don't care." Did she never shut up about her stupid friends? Like Catra really needed the reminder of how well Adora was doing without her. "What's with the boat? Is your rainbow pony sick?" she asked in a mocking tone.

Adora narrowed her eyes. "I didn't want Glimmer to notice us leaving and start asking questions, and Swift Wind, uh… Whatever, he's loud. Will you let me get up, please?"

"I'm so sorry, but I can't do that," Scorpia replied.

"What's going on?" Entrapta called out from across the water.

Catra turned to her with a devious grin. "Go get the rope."

After securing practiced knots around her wrists and ankles, Adora was propped up against a rock while Catra circled around it, dragging the sword through the sand behind her. Though the ocean was still in front of them, threatening to drag them her and Catra both out to sea, she had secured Adora to the shore.

Entrapta, thrashing around as she tried to yank the artifact out the water, was probably a different story.

Adora was looking a little too content for someone who had just been captured. An easy problem to solve. “Hey, Adora, can I ask you a question?”

Just as she opened her mouth to answer, Catra kicked a flurry of sand at her.

“Hey!” Adora yelled, making hilarious noises as she spit sand out of her mouth. “That was low.”

Catra threw her head back in a cackle. “You know nothing’s too low for me, princess.”

“I thought you would’ve learned your lesson after that time I replaced your ration bars with crushed gravel,” said Adora, wiping her face off with her arm.

“Consider it payback,” Catra replied, crossing her legs together as she lowered herself to the ground in front of Adora. “Besides, I knew that one was coming.”

Adora snorted. “You did not.”

“Did too,” Catra replied.

“Then why did you take a giant bite?” Adora asked with a little mocking smirk.

Catra shrugged. “I’ve always been the funny one, I figured you needed the win.”

“Yeah, right,” Adora said with a grin.

Catra couldn’t help the smile that itched at the corners of her mouth. There was a comfortable familiarity between them, even now. Even while sitting next to the stupid sword that turned her into a giant magical lady. So much had changed, but being with Adora still felt like home.

Catra pulled her knees up in front of her and wrapped her arms around her legs. “Remember that time we tried to turn Kyle’s hair purple by putting purple snail slime in his shampoo?”

Adora chuckled. “Don’t remind me. It didn’t even make it to his hair, he had an allergic reaction as soon as he touched it.”

“He ran all the way to the infirmary in a towel,” Catra said, cracking up at the memory.

“I felt so bad! Leave it to Kyle to be allergic to snails,” Adora replied, shaking her head.

“Don’t feel bad, he deserved it for being Kyle,” Catra said, hiding her grin behind her knees as Adora laughed and rolled her eyes.

The clouds had since cleared with the breeze, and the beach was once again bathed in bright light. Catra didn’t mind, though. Not with the way it was reflecting on Adora’s face. Her skin was glowing and her eyes were shining, deepening the already endless pools of blue. That was water Catra was more than willing to drown in.

Adora cocked an eyebrow. “What?”

“What?” Catra purred.

“You’re looking at me funny,” said Adora.

“Maybe that’s because you look funny,” Catra shot back, snapping back to reality.

“Can’t be funnier than the way you looked when I first got here, I didn’t even know you owned a hat,” Adora said with a smirk.

Catra blushed all over again. “I don’t. The Horde is getting creative with their torture devices.”

“You looked very tortured curled up on that rock,” Adora replied with an overly sincere nod.

Catra felt her chest start to heat, unsure if it was from anger or further embarrassment. “Why did you even dock here if you saw me? The entrance to Salineas is all the way over there,” she said, gesturing towards the sea gate.

Before Adora could answer, a loud splash filled the air and something hit the ground behind them with a loud *crash* . Startled, Catra leaped to her feet and whirled around to see an enormous piece of… something… on the shore. Junk. Scorpia was jumping up and down in front of it and waving her arms in the air. Exciting piece of junk, apparently.

“Stay there,” Catra demanded, narrowing her eyes at Adora.

“Couldn’t go anywhere if I wanted to,” Adora replied.

Catra gave her a satisfied smirk. Feeling a little less terrified than before, assured steps carried her down towards the water until she met with Entrapta and Scorpia at the shore. Whatever they found was huge. It was also mostly destroyed. “What is this thing?” she asked, scanning over the gray hunk of metal.

“Judging by the data collected by my drone, the First One’s tech in the engine is likely to be extremely large. Plus, look what I found when I dislodged it from the sand!” Entrapta proudly held up five shiny metal sticks covered in sand. “Tiny straws! They *could* be some sort of hyper specific piping that broke off when the vessel was destroyed, but after I run some tests to make sure the material isn’t toxic–”

“Focus!” Catra snapped. “This looks like trash, what is it?”

“A spaceship,” Entrapta said, tearing her eyes away from the metal pipes. “It’s *really* old. It looks like it might’ve been used to transport raw materials we don’t have on Etheria, but I won’t know until I can remove all the sand and take a closer look. The ship itself isn’t entirely intact, but I think enough of the engine is. We’ll have to bring it back to the Horde so I can dissect it!”

Catra nodded. “We’ll tie it to the bottom of the skiff, start dragging it over there. I’ll go get blondie.” She turned on her heel to return to where Adora was seated.

Adora smiled at her, and Catra did her best to smile back like someone who was happy to be taking her to prison and not someone who was just happy to have her home again.

“What is that?” Adora asked as Catra approached, looking over at the spaceship.

“None of your business. We’re taking you back to the Horde, stand up.”

“Already? What about your beach day fun?” Adora replied mockingly.

Before Catra could shoot back a sharp edged retort, Scorpia was calling for her attention.

“Catra!”

“What?” Catra snapped as she whirled around.

“You forgot to check out my sand shapes! Look, it’s us! Here’s you,” she said, pointing down and marvelling at the pile of shapeless sand below her, “here’s me, and here’s Entrapta! Told you I’m a bit of an artist.” She crossed her arms and looked back up Catra. Her excited smile instantly fell. “Uhh…” she said, staring over Catra’s shoulder.

Catra whipped around to find Adora cutting the last rope off of her ankles with a small knife. She glanced up with a grin, grabbed the sword, and started sprinting towards her boat.

“Damn it!” Catra yelled, and took off running after her.

By the time she caught up, Adora was already in the water, pushing her boat out to sea. Seething, Catra picked up a rock and chucked it at her. It missed.

"I hope you drown!" Catra yelled as Adora hopped into the boat.

Adora flashed her a smile, and Catra glared at her with rage so hot it could've evaporated the ocean between them. She wished it would.

"Nice seeing you!" Adora shouted as she steered the boat over the waves towards the sea gate.

Catra just stared as the water carried Adora farther and farther away. How could she have let this happen? Did Adora have that knife the whole time? She must've, right? Why didn't she use it earlier? It wasn't like she didn't have the opportunity to escape.

Catra frowned, but as the realization dawned on her, her fur slowly relaxed from its raised, angry state. Adora could've left at any time. She could've left, but she didn't. She stayed.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!